

Dog Separation Anxiety Guide — Action Checklist

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ASSESSMENT

- ☐ **Recognize Panic, Not Mischief:** Understand that your dog is experiencing a genuine panic response triggered by your departure cues, not acting out of anger or revenge, because this distinction determines the right treatment approach and prevents accidentally reinforcing harmful patterns.
- ☐ **Identify Your Dog's Anxiety Level:** Learn to recognize early signals like following you everywhere and refusing treats, escalated signals like howling and drooling, and severe signals like self-injury, because the intensity of your dog's anxiety determines whether the standard protocol is safe to use alone.
- ☐ **Know When to Seek Veterinary Support:** Determine whether your dog shows mild anxiety manageable with the standard protocol or moderate to severe symptoms requiring professional intervention, because dogs at the severe end of the spectrum may hurt themselves without veterinary behavioral support and medication.
- ☐ **Use Crate as Management, Not Treatment:** Stop treating your dog's crate as a cure for separation anxiety and view it only as a potential containment option, because for dogs in true panic, the crate becomes a trap that can lead to self-injury when they try to escape.

HARMFUL METHODS TO STOP

- ☐ **Stop Gradually Extending Alone Time:** Stop leaving your dog for progressively longer periods as a way to build tolerance, because failed separations deepen the panic cycle rather than weakening it and your dog learns to panic for longer instead of learning to cope.
 - ☐ **Eliminate Punishment After Returning Home:** Remove any punishment, scolding, or angry homecoming behavior when you return to destruction or accidents, because your dog destroyed things during panic not reflection and punishment only increases future anxiety and destruction.
 - ☐ **Stop Relying on Calming Products as Fixes:** Stop expecting ThunderShirts, Adaptil, CBD, or herbal supplements to cure your dog's separation anxiety, because these products offer temporary relief but cannot fix the underlying panic disorder on their own.
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- **Begin Systematic Desensitization Practice:** Start exposing your dog to graduated departure cues without actually leaving, beginning with small steps like picking up keys or putting on shoes without proceeding, because this weakens the anxiety association with departure signals over time.

BUILD THE PROTOCOL

- **Practice Departure Behaviors Until Calm:** Work through your departure routine repeatedly in short sessions until your dog shows no anxiety signals before you leave, because a calm dog at departure time means the protocol is working and you can proceed to actual departures.
- **Proceed to Brief Actual Separations:** Once your dog remains calm during departure cue practice, begin leaving for very short periods of just one to five minutes while maintaining the same calm departure routine, because successful short absences build the foundation for longer periods.
- **Contact a Veterinary Behaviorist if Needed:** Reach out to a veterinary behaviorist or certified professional trainer if your dog shows moderate to severe separation anxiety signs, because these professionals can create a comprehensive treatment plan combining behavior modification with medication when needed.
- **Accept That Recovery Takes Systematic Work:** Accept that separation anxiety requires systematic behavioral retraining rather than punishment or simply waiting for your dog to adjust, because the protocol works by changing how your dog emotionally experiences your departure over time through consistent practice.

Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.